

Intel launches new Xeon processors to empower visual cloud solutions

At Computex 2016, Intel launched its new Xeon processor family to expand the business around emerging visual cloud solutions. The new range of chips belongs to the all-new Intel Xeon E3-1500 v5 and comes with the graphics power of Intel Iris Pro graphics P580.

To deliver an accelerated experience for video streaming and graphics-intensive applications, the new Intel Xeon processors support hardware-assisted HEVC (High Efficiency Video Codec). They transcend 4K video playback without any visible lag.



Intel previewed a 360-degree live-streamed virtual reality jazz concert at its Computex keynote in Taiwan to show the hardware-assisted 4K video delivery capabilities of the new chips. The chipmaker claimed that the new chips have sufficient power to deliver up to 26 per cent more performance to complex CAD and content creation applications in virtualised environments when compared with the previous generation Intel Xeon E-1200 v4.

Based on the existing Skylake micro-architecture, the new Xeon family consists of four data centre graphics SKU models including Intel Xeon E3-1585 v5, E3-1585L v5 and E3-1565L v5, as well as two media processing SKU models—Xeon E3-1578L v5 and E3-1558L v5. All the six chips are capable of providing up to 18 advanced video coding (AVC) streams or eight HEVC streams at 1080p 30FPS, or two HEVC streams at 4K 30FPS.

The concept of the visual cloud isn't new for the tech world. However, Intel's latest development could bring some refinements to the existing trend. Intel claims that its new Xeon family will last for up to 10 years. Thus, the new processors are targeted at mainstream cloud and network service providers who are looking at solutions for the long term.



"By extending Ansible's capabilities into Microsoft Windows and Azure environments and into networking, our users can further expand their automation capabilities into their environment, helping to make their operations as hybrid as their IT," said Tim Cramer, head of Ansible Engineering, Red Hat, in a statement.

Red Hat has leveraged Azure's Resource Manager functionality to enable a broader support for hybrid cloud deployments. Likewise, some new Windows modules increase the automatable surface area of Microsoft's computing platform and access places such as Windows file sharing and firewalls.

The new Ansible version comes with NT LAN Manager (NTLM) to join together multiple machines without using Kerberos. There is also a reboot support with the new win_reboot action. Besides, the framework developers have rewritten the existing Docker modules and added a new docker_service module.

Red Hat claims that Ansible 2.1 includes over 40 new core modules to provide network automation support on a variety of platforms such as Arista EOS, Cisco IOS, Cisco NXOS, Cumulus Networks, Juniper Networks, Junos OS and OpenSwitch, among others.

You can access Ansible 2.1 directly through GitHub and PyPi. It is also available via the package manager of most Linux distributions.

Ansible came into the hands of Red Hat in October last year, as a result of the acquisition of Oregon-based Puppet Labs. The new update emerges as the second new version and the most significant one since the buyout.

Canonical brings Snaps to multiple Linux distros

Ubuntu maker Canonical has partnered with a few leading tech companies to launch its Snappy as a universal Linux package format. With this new development, the single binary package can now be accessed directly through any Linux hardware — whether it is a desktop, server, the cloud or a connected device.

Snaps debuted on Ubuntu Core, and recently transformed the experience with its secure features on the latest Ubuntu platform. This is perhaps the major reason why companies like Dell and Samsung have agreed to use the new development for their devices.

Though Linux has supported Deb packages for quite a long time, it has now been considered inefficient to maintain Debs. Thus, Snaps has emerged as a solution.

"Maintaining Deb packages in a private repository was complex and time-consuming. Snaps are much easier to maintain, package and distribute," said Boudewijn Rempt, project lead at the Krita Foundation. "Putting the Snap in the store was particularly simple; this is the most streamlined app store I have published software in," he added.

Canonical is not apparently looking to replace existing Linux packages with its Snappy platform package. Instead, the new development will "...sit alongside the native packages," to expand the coverage of the open source world.

Starting from desktop and mobile devices to the cloud and the Internet of Things (IoT), Snaps now aims to power the entire Linux world. For Canonical, data security is one of the prime factors for this adoption. Besides, universal availability will also persuade the Linux community worldwide to opt for the new solution.